Unit 1, Day 1: What Happens When You Stop Seeking Approval

Selected Readings · ACT / SAT / GRE / FAST verbal practice

Name _____ Date _____ Start time _____ End time _____

Part	Format	Items	Time
Passage	Read once, closely. Mark the claim of each paragraph in the margin.	11 paragraphs	8 min
Section 1	ACT Reading	10	10 minutes
Section 2	SAT Reading and Writing	10	12 minutes
Section 3	ACT English	3	2 minutes
Section 4	GRE Verbal Reasoning	7	10 minutes
Section 5	FAST ELA Reading	4	8 minutes
Section 5, continued	FAST Writing: text-based argumentative essay	1 essay	45 min

The passage

Adapted from the transcript of a video essay on the Bygone Philosophy channel. Paragraphs are numbered for reference.

1 Every man's chief and real existence is in his own skin and not in other people's opinions. Arthur Schopenhauer wrote that in the 1850s. And in the same essay, he warned what happens to the man who forgets it. He becomes, in Schopenhauer's words, the slave of what other people are pleased to think. Not their servant, their slave. Because a servant can quit, but a man who needs approval carries his master everywhere. Into every meeting, every conversation, every decision about what to say, what to wear, what to want. He laughs a little louder at the joke. He agrees a little faster than he believes. He explains himself to people who never asked. And at night, he replays the day, checking how he came across. Most men live like this without ever noticing. And most will never find out what happens when it stops.

2 So, let's go through it. What actually happens, in the order it happens, when a man stops seeking approval.

3 The first thing that happens is that you notice how often you were doing it. The moment you decide to stop, you start catching yourself. The message you rewrite four times so it sounds right. The opinion you soften before anyone has even pushed back. The story you tell about yourself that's a little better than the truth. The urge to explain why you said no when no was a complete answer. It's uncomfortable because

you realize how much of your day was a performance. How much of your energy was going into managing what other people think of you instead of into your actual life. Don't fight that discomfort. It's the first sign you're waking up.

4 The second thing that happens is that some people react. When you stop agreeing with everything, someone will be surprised. When you stop saying yes to every request, someone will be disappointed. When you stop laughing at the jokes that aren't funny, someone will notice the silence, and a few people may pull away. Here's what you need to understand. Those people didn't lose you. They lost a version of you that was built to please them. If a relationship only survives as long as you're performing, it was never a relationship with you. It was a relationship with the performance. This is the stage where most men turn back. The discomfort that feels like proof they've made a mistake. It isn't. It's the cost of becoming visible.

5 The third thing that happens is that you get your energy back. The psychologist Jennifer Crocker spent years studying what she called contingencies of self-worth, the things people believe they have to get right in order to feel worthy. In one study at the University of Michigan, her team followed more than 600 college freshmen through their first year. More than a third said that other people's approval was important to how they valued themselves. And the students whose self-worth rested on outside sources like approval, appearance, and outdoing others did worse. They reported more stress and more anger. They drank and used drugs more. They showed more signs of disordered eating. And these links held even after the researchers accounted for how high or low their self-esteem was overall. Think about what that means. It wasn't low confidence that was hurting them. It was where their confidence was stored. When your worth is held in other people's hands, every interaction becomes a test you can fail. You are always on trial, and a man who is always on trial is always exhausted. When you stop seeking approval, the trial ends. That energy doesn't disappear. It comes back to you.

6 The fourth thing that happens is that your work changes. In 1973 at a nursery school at Stanford, the psychologists Mark Lepper, David Greene, and Richard Nisbett found children who already loved drawing. They told some of them that if they drew, they would win a good player award, a certificate with a gold seal and a red ribbon. The children drew, and they got their award. Then, one to two weeks later, the researchers quietly put the markers back out during free play and watched. The children who had drawn for the award now spent about half as much of their free time drawing as the children who had never been promised anything. They hadn't stopped being able to draw. They had stopped drawing for themselves. Something they did out of love had turned into something they did for a ribbon. And when the ribbon was gone, so was the desire. That is what approval-seeking does to a man's work. You stop asking whether it's good and start asking whether it will be liked. You write what gets applause. You train for how it looks. You choose the career that sounds impressive. And slowly, the things you once loved start to feel like obligations. When you stop seeking approval, you get back the boy who drew because he wanted to. The work becomes yours again. And work that is truly yours is almost always better because you are finally paying attention to the work instead of the audience.

7 The fifth thing that happens is that your relationships get deeper. Crocker and her colleague Amy Canevello later followed students sharing dorm rooms with strangers. Some went into those relationships focused on protecting their image, on making sure they looked good. Others went in genuinely trying to support the other person. The image-focused students were less likely to say their relationships were

improving. The ones who gave support out of real concern built the closest and most supportive relationships. As Canevello put it, we get support by being supportive. This is the hidden irony. The man who seeks approval thinks he is focused on other people. He isn't. He is focused on himself, on how he is coming across. He's not listening to you. He's watching his own reflection in your eyes. When you stop needing their approval, you can finally pay attention to them. You can listen without planning your next impressive line. You can tell a friend a hard truth because you're not afraid of losing his good opinion. And people can feel the difference.

8 And that leads to the last thing that happens, the paradox. When you stop seeking approval, people begin to respect you more. Psychologists who study flattery, going back to Edward Jones in the 1960s, describe something called the ingratiator's dilemma. The more obviously you depend on someone's approval, the more they suspect your praise and agreement are a strategy. So, flattery is most likely to backfire exactly when you need it most. People can sense the need behind it. And need, displayed openly, makes everything you say worth less. The man who doesn't need your approval is different. When he agrees with you, it means something because he would have told you if he didn't. When he praises you, you believe it. His yes is worth something because his no is real.

9 Now, be careful here. Not seeking approval does not mean not caring what anyone thinks. A man who ignores every voice isn't free. He's just deaf. There's a difference between approval and feedback. Approval is about whether people like you. Feedback is about whether you're right. A strong man stops chasing the first and actively hunts for the second from the few people whose judgment he has earned reason to trust.

10 So, how do you begin? Start by noticing. For one week, count every time you explain yourself to someone who didn't ask, apologize for something that wasn't wrong, or agree with something you don't believe. Don't judge it. Just count. You can't drop a habit you can't see. Then say no once without an excuse. Just no. Feel how uncomfortable it is and notice that nothing collapses. Say one honest opinion where you would normally stay quiet. Not to provoke anyone, just to let your real view exist out loud. Do one thing this week purely because you want to and tell no one about it. No post, no story, no audience. Let it be yours, and choose deliberately the handful of people whose judgment you'll actually listen to. Everyone else's opinion is weather. You notice it and you keep walking.

11 Schopenhauer was right. Your real existence is in your own skin, not in the head of the person you're trying to impress, not in the comments, not in the room's reaction. So, when you stop seeking approval, here's what really happens. You come home. And for the first time in a long time, the man living your life is you.

Section 1: ACT Reading

Directions. The passage is followed by several questions. After reading the passage, choose the best answer to each question. You may refer to the passage as often as necessary. *10 questions · 10 minutes*

1. MAIN IDEA

The main purpose of the passage is to:

A. describe, in order, the changes that follow when a person stops seeking approval, and advise how to begin.

B. summarize Schopenhauer's philosophy of human existence.

C. argue that other people's opinions should be ignored entirely.

D. report the results of a single study of college freshmen.

2. DETAIL (EXCEPT)

According to Paragraph 5, the students whose self-worth rested on outside sources showed all of the following EXCEPT:

F. more stress.

G. more drinking and drug use.

H. more signs of disordered eating.

J. lower overall self-esteem.

3. VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

As it is used in Paragraph 5 ("It was where their confidence was stored"), the word stored most nearly means:

A. placed.

B. delayed.

C. purchased.

D. concealed.

4. FUNCTION OF A PARAGRAPH

The main function of Paragraph 6 in relation to the passage as a whole is to:

F. offer evidence that an outside reward can replace a person's own reason for doing something, supporting the claim that approval-seeking changes a person's work.

G. criticize nursery schools for giving children awards.

H. introduce the ingratiator's dilemma.

J. show that rewarded children lose the ability to draw.

5. INFERENCE

It can reasonably be inferred from Paragraph 4 that the people who "pull away" are mainly reacting to:

- **A.** the end of behavior that had been designed to please them.
- **B.** new rudeness from the person who changed.
- **C.** a decline in the person's abilities.
- **D.** criticism the person directed at them.

6. AUTHOR'S VIEW

The author's attitude toward feedback, as distinguished from approval, is best described as:

- **F.** dismissive.
- **G.** favorable, provided it comes from a few trusted people.
- **H.** suspicious of feedback from any source.
- **J.** indifferent.

7. CAUSE AND EFFECT

According to Paragraph 8, flattery is most likely to backfire when the person giving it:

- **A.** obviously depends on the other person's approval.
- **B.** offers it in private.
- **C.** barely knows the person being flattered.
- **D.** means every word of it.

8. COMPARISON

In Paragraph 1, the contrast between a servant and a slave mainly suggests that:

- **F.** servants are paid and slaves are not.
- **G.** a servant can leave his master, while a person who needs approval carries that need everywhere.
- **H.** Schopenhauer wrote about the history of slavery.
- **J.** people who seek approval usually work as servants.

9. ORGANIZATION

Which of the following best describes how Paragraphs 3 through 8 are organized?

- **A.** A series of consequences presented in the order the author says they occur
- **B.** A list of objections, each followed by a rebuttal
- **C.** A chronological account of Schopenhauer's life
- **D.** A comparison of two competing studies

10. PURPOSE OF A PARAGRAPH

The last paragraph mainly serves to:

F. introduce a new study that supports the main claim.

G. return to the opening quotation and restate the claim through the image of coming home.

H. admit that the author's earlier claims were exaggerated.

J. summarize the findings of Crocker's research.

Section 2: SAT Reading and Writing

Directions. The questions in this section address a number of important reading and writing skills. Each question includes one or more passages. Read each passage and question carefully, and then choose the best answer to the question based on the passage(s). All questions in this section are multiple-choice with four answer choices. Each question has a single best answer. *10 questions · 12 minutes*

1. WORDS IN CONTEXT

> Psychologists who study flattery, going back to Edward Jones in the 1960s, describe something called the ingratiator's dilemma. The more obviously you depend on someone's approval, the more they suspect your praise and agreement are a . So, flattery is most likely to backfire exactly when you need it most.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- **A.** strategy
- **B.** compliment
- **C.** coincidence
- **D.** sacrifice

2. TEXT STRUCTURE AND PURPOSE

> Now, be careful here. Not seeking approval does not mean not caring what anyone thinks. A man who ignores every voice isn't free. He's just deaf. There's a difference between approval and feedback. Approval is about whether people like you. Feedback is about whether you're right.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- **A.** It qualifies the author's advice so that it cannot be read as a call to disregard every opinion.
- **B.** It presents evidence from a psychological study.
- **C.** It contradicts the author's main claim about approval.
- **D.** It describes a common habit of people who seek approval.

3. CENTRAL IDEAS AND DETAILS

> In 1973 at a nursery school at Stanford, psychologists found children who already loved drawing. They told some of them that if they drew, they would win a good player award. One to two weeks later, the children who had drawn for the award spent about half as much of their free time drawing as the children who had never been promised anything. They hadn't stopped being able to draw. They had stopped drawing for themselves.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- **A.** A promised reward appeared to replace the children's own reason for drawing, so they drew less once it was gone.
- **B.** Children draw more skillfully when they are promised an award.
- **C.** Nursery school children prefer certificates to free play.
- **D.** Stanford psychologists studied art education in the 1970s.

4. COMMAND OF EVIDENCE (TEXTUAL)

> The author claims that the harm Jennifer Crocker found among college freshmen came from where students placed their self-worth, not from how much self-esteem they had.

Which quotation from the passage most effectively supports this claim?

A. "Her team followed more than 600 college freshmen through their first year."

B. "More than a third said that other people's approval was important to how they valued themselves."

C. "These links held even after the researchers accounted for how high or low their self-esteem was overall."

D. "They reported more stress and more anger."

5. INFERENCES

> In a 1973 study, children who already loved drawing were told they could win an award for drawing. One to two weeks later, children who had drawn for the award spent about half as much free time drawing as children who had never been promised anything. Because the rewarded children had not lost the ability to draw, the result suggests that

Which choice most logically completes the text?

A. the award had changed why they drew, so their desire to draw left with it.

B. the children had never really enjoyed drawing.

C. the markers had become less appealing over time.

D. children who receive awards draw more skillfully.

6. CROSS-TEXT CONNECTIONS

Text 1 is from the approval essay. Text 2 is from an essay on the seventeenth-century writer Baltasar Gracián.

> Text 1: Then say no once without an excuse. Just no. Feel how uncomfortable it is and notice that nothing collapses.
>
> Text 2: A gilded no is more satisfactory than a dry yes. Some people agree so grudgingly, they get no credit for it. Others decline so warmly, the other person walks away feeling respected. Don't make a refusal blunt and final. Let it land gently. Give a real reason and where you honestly can, leave some hope.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the advice in Text 1?

A. By cautioning that a bare refusal may land harshly, and recommending a real reason instead

B. By agreeing that refusals should never include reasons

C. By arguing that a person should avoid refusing at all

D. By claiming that discomfort shows a refusal was a mistake

7. RHETORICAL SYNTHESIS

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

> • In 1973, Mark Lepper, David Greene, and Richard Nisbett studied children at a Stanford nursery school.
>
> • The children already enjoyed drawing.
>
> • Some were promised a "good player award" if they drew.
>
> • One to two weeks later, children who had drawn for the award spent about half as much free time drawing as children who had been promised nothing.

The student wants to present the study's main finding to an audience unfamiliar with it. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A. In a 1973 study, preschoolers who had drawn for a promised award later spent about half as much free time drawing as children who had been promised nothing.

B. Mark Lepper, David Greene, and Richard Nisbett conducted a study at Stanford in 1973.

C. The children in the study already enjoyed drawing before it began.

D. Some children were promised a "good player award," while others were not.

8. TRANSITIONS

> Crocker's team found that students whose self-worth depended on approval reported more stress and more anger. these links held even after the researchers accounted for the students' overall self-esteem.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A. However,

B. Moreover,

C. For instance,

D. Instead,

9. BOUNDARIES

> A servant can a man who needs approval carries his master everywhere.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A. quit, but

B. quit but

C. quit; but

D. quit, but,

10. FORM, STRUCTURE, AND SENSE

> The students whose self-worth rested on outside sources like approval, appearance, and outdoing others more stress and more anger.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- **A.** reports
- **B.** was reporting
- **C.** reported
- **D.** has reported

Section 3: ACT English

Directions. In the passages that follow, certain words and phrases are underlined. For each question, choose the alternative you consider best. If you think the original version is best, choose NO CHANGE. Some questions ask about a section of the passage or the passage as a whole.

3 questions · 2 minutes

11. SENTENCE BOUNDARIES

> Here's what you need to understand. Those people didn't lose you, they lost a version of you that was built to please them.

Which choice is best for the underlined portion?

- **A.** NO CHANGE
- **B.** you. They lost
- **C.** you they lost
- **D.** you, which lost

12. REDUNDANCY

> The children drew, and they got their award, receiving the certificate they were promised.

Which choice is best for the underlined portion?

- **F.** NO CHANGE
- **G.** award, receiving a certificate.
- **H.** award, which was the certificate.
- **J.** award.

13. RELEVANCE

> At this point in Paragraph 1, the writer is considering adding the following sentence: "Schopenhauer was born in Danzig in 1788."

Should the writer make this addition here?

- **A.** Yes, because it gives useful background on the philosopher being quoted.
- **B.** Yes, because it explains why Schopenhauer wrote about opinions.
- **C.** No, because it would distract from the paragraph's focus on what happens to a person who needs approval.
- **D.** No, because it contradicts the date given for Schopenhauer's essay.

Section 4: GRE Verbal Reasoning

Directions. Each question type has its own directions, printed with the question. Text completion and sentence equivalence questions give no partial credit: every blank, or both choices, must be correct. Reading comprehension questions refer to the passage at the front of this booklet.

7 questions · 10 minutes

1. TEXT COMPLETION (ONE BLANK)

> The ingratiator's dilemma suggests that flattery defeats itself: the more a speaker appears, the less his praise is believed.

Select one entry for the blank. Fill the blank in the way that best completes the text.

- **A.** candid
- **B.** obsequious
- **C.** reticent
- **D.** impartial
- **E.** laconic

2. TEXT COMPLETION (TWO BLANKS)

> Crocker's findings were notable less for showing that approval-seeking students struggled than for showing that their difficulties were (i) their overall self-esteem: the harm persisted even when that variable was (ii) .

For each blank, select one entry from the corresponding column of choices. Fill all blanks in the way that best completes the text.

Blank (i)	Blank (ii)
☐ independent of	☐ ignored
☐ caused by	☐ accounted for
☐ identical to	☐ exaggerated

3. SENTENCE EQUIVALENCE

> Rather than winning respect, the approval seeker's constant agreement tends to make his opinions seem .

Select the two answer choices that, when used to complete the sentence, fit the meaning of the sentence as a whole and produce completed sentences that are alike in meaning.

Select two answers.

- **A.** empty
- **B.** hollow
- **C.** sincere
- **D.** persuasive
- **E.** novel
- **F.** weighty

4. SENTENCE EQUIVALENCE

> The author is careful to note that freedom from approval is not the same as : a man who ignores every voice is not free, merely deaf.

Select the two answer choices that, when used to complete the sentence, fit the meaning of the sentence as a whole and produce completed sentences that are alike in meaning.

Select two answers.

- **A.** heedlessness
- **B.** obliviousness
- **C.** humility
- **D.** diligence
- **E.** deference
- **F.** candor

5. READING COMPREHENSION (SELECT ALL THAT APPLY)

Consider each of the choices separately and select all that apply. Based on the passage, which of the following does the author present as consequences of no longer seeking approval?

Select all that apply.

- **A.** Some people may withdraw from the relationship.
- **B.** The person's energy returns.
- **C.** The person's overall self-esteem increases.

6. READING COMPREHENSION (SELECT IN PASSAGE)

Select the sentence in Paragraph 8 in which the author explains why the agreement of a person who does not need approval is believable.

1. "So, flattery is most likely to backfire exactly when you need it most."
2. "People can sense the need behind it."
3. "The man who doesn't need your approval is different."
4. "When he agrees with you, it means something because he would have told you if he didn't."
5. "His yes is worth something because his no is real."

7. READING COMPREHENSION (ARGUMENT)

The author uses the 1973 drawing study to conclude that seeking approval makes an adult's work worse. Which of the following, if true, would most seriously weaken that conclusion?

- **A.** The children in the study already loved drawing before the study began.
- **B.** Studies of adult employees found that expected rewards did not reduce how much time they chose to spend on their work.
- **C.** Some children in the study were never promised an award.
- **D.** Awards and approval both come from other people.
- **E.** Many adults choose careers partly for prestige.

Section 5: FAST ELA Reading

Directions. Answer the questions about the passage at the front of this booklet. Some questions have two parts: answer Part A first, then Part B. Some questions ask you to select more than one answer; select the number of answers the question asks for.

4 items · 8 minutes

1, Part A. CENTRAL IDEA (EVIDENCE-BASED SELECTED RESPONSE)

Which statement best describes a central idea of the passage?

A. Depending on approval costs a person energy, quality of work, and closeness with others.

B. People who ignore every opinion are the most free.

C. Flattery is the most reliable way to earn respect.

D. Schopenhauer's ideas have been disproved by modern research.

1, Part B. SUPPORTING EVIDENCE (SELECT TWO)

Which two sentences from the passage best support the answer to Part A? Select two.

Select two answers.

A. "You are always on trial, and a man who is always on trial is always exhausted."

B. "Arthur Schopenhauer wrote that in the 1850s."

C. "And work that is truly yours is almost always better because you are finally paying attention to the work instead of the audience."

D. "So, let's go through it."

E. "Psychologists who study flattery, going back to Edward Jones in the 1960s, describe something called the ingratiator's dilemma."

2. FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE (SELECT TWO)

Which two phrases from the passage use figurative language to describe dependence on approval? Select two.

Select two answers.

A. "carries his master everywhere"

B. "followed more than 600 college freshmen"

C. "You are always on trial"

D. "one to two weeks later"

E. "a certificate with a gold seal"

3. AUTHOR'S DEVELOPMENT OF A CLAIM

How does the author develop the claim that people who stop seeking approval earn more respect?

A. By describing a psychological concept and explaining why visible need makes praise less believable

B. By telling a personal story about losing a friend

C. By presenting statistics from a survey of employers

D. By quoting Schopenhauer's views on respect

Section 5, continued: FAST Writing

Prompt. Some people believe a refusal should be short and unexplained. Others believe a refusal should come with a reason. Write an argumentative essay in which you take a position on whether people should explain their refusals. Use evidence from both sources to support your position. Address an opposing claim. Your essay should have an introduction, body paragraphs, and a conclusion, and should be written in a formal style. *45 minutes*

Source 1: the passage at the front of this booklet. Paragraphs 8, 9, and 10 bear most directly on refusing.

Source 2: from "The Socially Intelligent"
With refusing, he has one of the best lines in the whole book. A gilded no is more satisfactory than a dry yes. Some people agree so grudgingly, they get no credit for it. Others decline so warmly, the other person walks away feeling respected. Don't make a refusal blunt and final. Let it land gently. Give a real reason and where you honestly can, leave some hope. Not this month, but ask me again in spring often goes down better than a yes you'll resent.

Planning space

Essay

FAST writing rubric (B.E.S.T.)

Each domain is scored 1 to 4, for a total out of 12. A 4 meets the full description below. A 3 meets most of it, a 2 some of it, and a 1 little of it.

Domain	What a 4 looks like	Score
Purpose/Structure	Clear, arguable claim maintained throughout. Logical progression with an introduction, transitions between reasons, and a conclusion that follows from the argument. Addresses the counterclaim.	/ 4
Development	Evidence from both sources, smoothly integrated and cited. Each quotation is followed by elaboration that explains how it supports the claim, not a restatement of it.	/ 4
Language	Precise word choice and varied sentences suited to an academic audience. Few errors in grammar, usage, capitalization, punctuation, and spelling.	/ 4
Total		/ 12

Score report

Section	Correct	Skills missed
ACT Reading	/ 10	
SAT Reading and Writing	/ 10	
ACT English	/ 3	
GRE Verbal Reasoning	/ 7	
FAST ELA Reading	/ 4	
FAST Writing	/ 12	

For every miss, write the skill label printed on the question and the reason the wrong choice was tempting: too broad, too narrow, opposite, not stated, outside knowledge, or right word but wrong job.

Answer sheet

Fill in one bubble per question unless the question says to select two or select all that apply.

Section 1: ACT Reading

1	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**2**	(F) (G) (H) (J)
3	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**4**	(F) (G) (H) (J)
5	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**6**	(F) (G) (H) (J)
7	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**8**	(F) (G) (H) (J)
9	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**10**	(F) (G) (H) (J)

Section 2: SAT Reading and Writing

1	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**2**	(A) (B) (C) (D)
3	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**4**	(A) (B) (C) (D)
5	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**6**	(A) (B) (C) (D)
7	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**8**	(A) (B) (C) (D)
9	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**10**	(A) (B) (C) (D)

Section 3: ACT English

11	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**12**	(F) (G) (H) (J)
13	(A) (B) (C) (D)		

Section 4: GRE Verbal Reasoning

1	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E)	**2**	(i) ____ (ii) ____
3	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E) (F)	**4**	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E) (F)
5	(A) (B) (C)	**6**	(1) (2) (3) (4) (5)
7	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E)		

Section 5: FAST ELA Reading

1, Part A	(A) (B) (C) (D)	**1, Part B**	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E)
2	(A) (B) (C) (D) (E)	**3**	(A) (B) (C) (D)